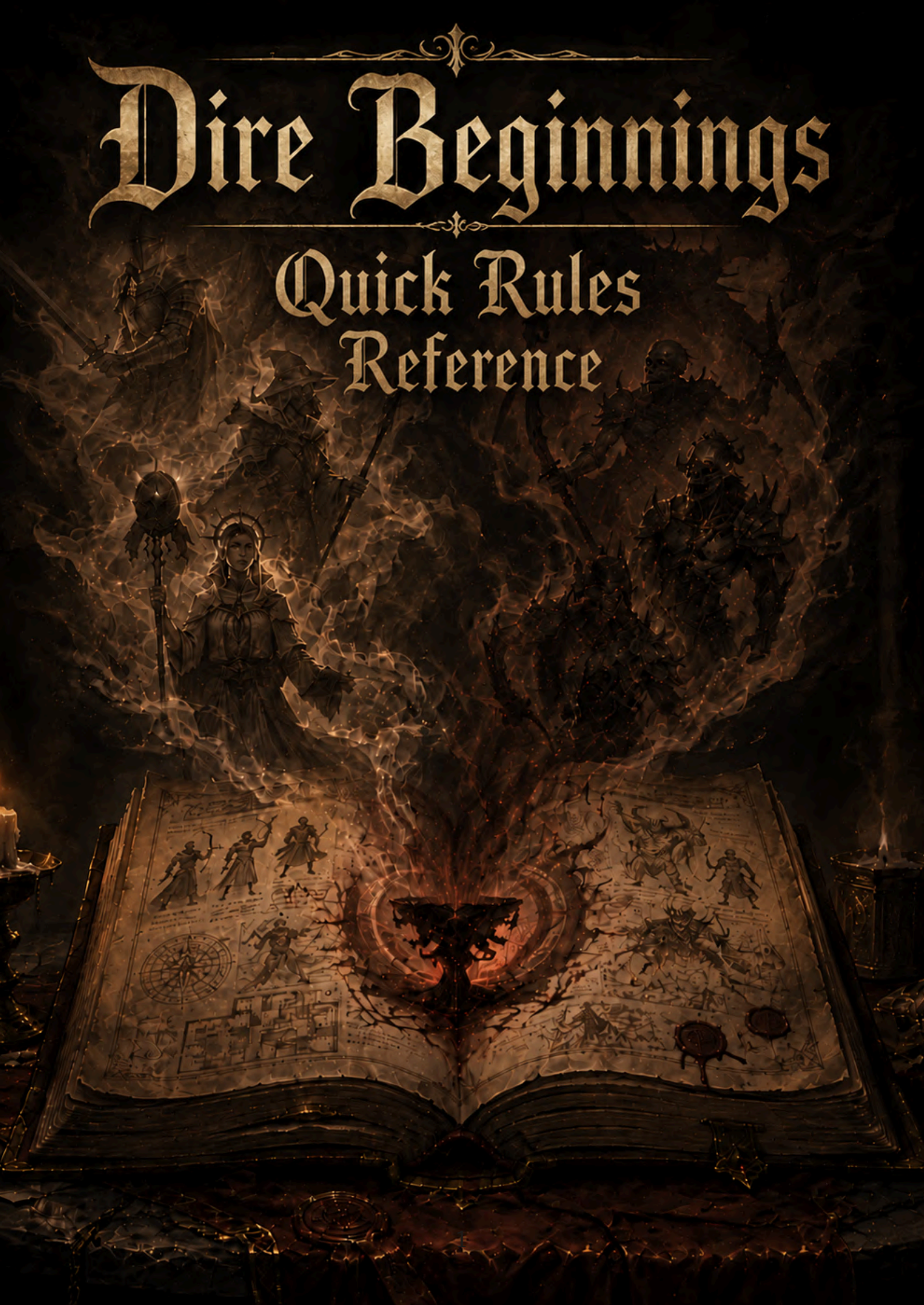
Dire Beginnings

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What is this Book

This guide teaches only what you need to set up a to immediately jump into playing one adventure to try the game.
For your first game, ignore the Town Phase, Legacy rules, campaign difficulty, unlocks, and long-term progression. Treat your first adventure as a standalone mission into the world of Soulless Vessel.

Should your party want to continue with normal campaign and legacy gameplay, you should read the full rules to understand other aspects of the game.

What is Dire Beginnings

Dire Beginnings is a cooperative dungeon crawler for 1 to 4 players.

The players control 4 heroes. If fewer than 4 players are playing, some players control more than one hero.

The game controls the enemies through Enemy Reference Cards and AI Cards.

Your goal is to complete the adventure objective shown in the Questbook before the heroes are defeated or the Doom Clock bleeds you dry.

Set Up Your First Party

Choose 4 available heroes.

For an easy first party, you can use a classic spread:

- Knight: durable frontliner
- Ranger: ranged damage and control
- Wizard: spell damage and utility
- Priest: healing and divine support

For each hero, take:

- Hero Reference Card
- Starting Ability Cards
- Starting Equipment Cards
- Matching standee
- Health tokens equal to maximum Health
- Stamina tokens equal to maximum Stamina

Note: Info on the starting abilities and items can be found towards the end of the full Rule Book.

Each hero starts the adventure with:

- Full Health, as indicated in the top left corner of the reference card
- 0 available Stamina, as indicated below their health value
- 0 Fatigue
- No Injury cards
- All ability cards in hand
- Starting items equipped as chosen by the player

Set Up The Adventure

For your first game, choose:
1A: The Strange Sorcerer

Then follow the Questbook:

1. Build the map shown for the adventure.
2. Place only the starting room or corridor and anything already visible there.
3. Place the 4 heroes on the dungeon entrance spaces.
4. Place doors and props shown in the revealed starting area.
5. Set the Doom Clock to the value listed in the Questbook.
6. Place the listed number of Resurrection Boons near the Doom Clock.
7. Shuffle the AI deck.
8. Read the adventure introduction and objective aloud.

Do not place anything from unrevealed rooms yet.

Core Dice Rules

The game uses d6, d8, and d10.

Most checks use a difficulty of 4+.

Each die that rolls equal to or higher than the difficulty is 1 success.

For example, if you roll 4d6 and get 1, 3, 4, and 6, you have 2 successes.

Dice Options

Some weapons, items, armor, and abilities list dice options.

A dice option lets you spend a die showing a certain result to trigger an effect.

When you spend a die on an option, that die no longer counts for the normal result of the roll.

Example: If you spend a successful attack die on a weapon option, that die no longer deals its normal 1 damage.

Each option can usually be used only once per action.

If an option shows a range, for example shown as [1] [4], any one die in that range from 1 to 4 can trigger it.

If an option shows x2, it requires two dice of that type.

Stamina and Fatigue

Stamina is your action currency.

Heroes spend Stamina to move, attack, play abilities, assist, interact and defend.

Unspent Stamina stays with the hero between rounds, but a hero can never have more Stamina than their current maximum..

Fatigue reduces a hero's maximum Stamina.

Example: If a hero has maximum Stamina 6 and suffers 2 Fatigue, their current maximum Stamina becomes 4.

Round Structure

Each round has 5 steps:

1. Start of Round
2. Stamina Checks
3. Initiative Planning
4. Hero and Enemy Turns
5. End of Round

Repeat rounds until the adventure is won, failed, or all heroes are dead.

Start of Round

Resolve the below steps in order.

1. Advance the Doom Clock

At the start of each round, decrease the Doom Clock by 1.

Do not decrease it during the first round.

If the Doom Clock would go below 0, keep it at 0. Then each living hero must Banish 1 ability card from their hand or discard pile.

A Banished card is removed for the rest of the adventure.

If a hero must Banish a card but has no ability cards left, that hero dies.

2. Assign Enemy AI Cards

Each active enemy group gets 1 AI card.

Draw AI cards for enemy groups in order of their distance from the dungeon entrance, with the

group that has one model the closest drawing first.

Players may inspect assigned AI cards. This tells the party when enemies will act, who they might target, and whether special enemy abilities are active this round.

Some AI cards may grant that group modifiers for the entire round, like increased damage.

> **Enemies with Rush**
> If enemies gain the Rush keyword (for example from one of the AI cards), it will take its entire turn immediately, but only after the Initiative Planning and Stamina checks.
>
> That enemy group does not act a second time during their regular initiative step.

3. Resolve Beginning of Round Effects

Resolve any effects that happen at the beginning of the round.

If several happen at the same time, the players choose the order unless a rule says otherwise.

Stamina Checks

Each living hero rolls **4d6**.

Every die showing **4+** is 1 success.

The hero gains:
1 Stamina + 1 Stamina per success

Example: If a hero rolls 3 successes, they gain 4 Stamina.

A hero cannot exceed their current maximum Stamina.

After rolling, a hero may suffer 1 Fatigue to reroll any number of dice from that Stamina Check.

This can be repeated, but Fatigue lowers maximum Stamina, so greed can turn the hero into a wheezing decorative statue.

Initiative Planning

Players choose the order in which the 4 heroes will act this round.

Then insert enemies based on their AI cards.

Enemy AI cards have an Initiative value from 1 to 4:

- Initiative 1: acts after the first hero
- Initiative 2: acts after the second hero
- Initiative 3: acts after the third hero
- Initiative 4: acts after the fourth hero

If multiple enemy groups act in the same slot, they act in the order their AI cards were assigned.

Hero Turns

On a hero's turn, that hero may spend any amount of their available Stamina.

The hero may move, attack, play abilities, interact, use consumables, or save Stamina for later.

When the player says the hero is done, that hero's turn ends.

> **End Of Turn Recovery**
> Whenever a hero ends their turn and they did not play an ability, nor performed an attack, they **Rest 1** (they recover 1 Fatigue).
>
> They can still perform other actions to remain eligible for this effect, like move, meditate, use consumable or interact.

Basic Actions

Below you will find a list of all actions a hero can perform with their stamina.

Move

Cost: 1 Stamina

Gain movement points equal to the hero's Speed.
Movement points can be used to:

- Move across the board
- Re-equip one item slot
- Trade an item with adjacent hero
- Use movement options for other special effects

Each movement point moves the hero 1 space.

Unused movement points are lost when the hero performs another action.

Standard Attack

Cost: 1 Stamina

Attack with one equipped weapon against an enemy within range.

A hero may perform only one Standard Attack per weapon per round, and never more than two Standard Attacks total per round.

Attacks granted by ability cards do not count against this limit.

Meditate

Cost: 2 Stamina

Roll 1d6 for each discarded ability card.

Each **4+** is 1 success.
Return discarded ability cards to hand equal to:
1 + successes

Maximum: 3 cards, regardless of successes.

Even with no successes, the hero returns 1 discarded ability card.

Interact

Cost: 1 Stamina

Interact with something in the hero's space or an adjacent space.

Common uses include:

- Opening treasure chests
- Activating objectives
- Searching something described by the Questbook
- Using an adventure-specific object

Use Consumable

Cost: 1 Stamina

Use one consumable item from the hero's backpack.

Resolve its effect, then return it to the item deck as instructed.

Assist

Cost: 1 Stamina

This action is an exception, as it can happen outside the hero's turn.

This action is performed when another hero makes an attack, spellcasting or defense roll.

The assisting hero may immediately Move 1 towards the hero making the check in question.

Only if the assisting hero becomes adjacent does their assist action fully unfold.

The assistant rolls **2d6**, and chooses one of the dice to replace a die of the assisted hero.

This can be used to generate more successes or to trigger specific dice options.

Ability Cards

A hero may only play ability cards during their own turn unless the card says it can be played at another time.

To play an ability:

1. Pay its cost: either stamina, fatigue, health or no cost (green dot).
2. Resolve its effect.
3. Place it in the hero's discard pile.

A hero may play any number of abilities as long as they can pay for them.

However, each ability can only be used **once** per round, even if it returns to the hero's hand during that round.

Interrupt
An Interrupt ability can be played outside the hero's turn when its timing allows.

Resolve it immediately, then continue the interrupted game flow.

Rush
A Rush ability lets a hero act earlier.

Resolve the Rush ability like an Interrupt, then that hero takes their full turn immediately.

If the hero already took a turn this round, they only resolve the Rush ability and do not take another full turn.

Movement, Range and Line Of Sight
The board is divided into square spaces.

Most models occupy 1 space.

A model cannot end movement on an occupied space unless a rule says otherwise.

Diagonal movement is allowed.

Heroes may move through allied heroes and allied minions, but not through enemies.

Enemies may move through enemies, but not through heroes or hero-controlled minions.

Spaces that are covered by low props without a grid across them (like tables and chairs) cannot be occupied.

Range
Count spaces from the source to the target.

Diagonal spaces count as 1.

If the counted distance is equal to or lower than the listed range, the target is within range.

Line Of Sight
Attacks or abilities that state a specific range also require Line of Sight.

Draw an imaginary line from the center of the source's space to the center of the target's space.

Line of Sight is blocked by:
- White walls
- Red blocking lines
- Terrain or props that block Line of Sight

If the line only touches the outer corner of a blocking space or line, Line of Sight is still available.

Adjacency
A model is adjacent if it is next to another model or space, including diagonally.
Adjacency also requires Line of Sight.

Attacking Enemies
An attack usually requires:
- A valid target
- An equipped weapon
- Range to the target
- Line of Sight to the target

Melee weapons usually attack adjacent enemies.

Ranged weapons use their listed Range value.

To attack:
1. Choose an equipped weapon.
2. Choose a valid target within range and Line of Sight.

3. Gather the weapon's attack dice.
4. Add or modify dice from abilities, items, traits, or effects.
5. Roll all attack dice.
6. Assign dice to any options you want to trigger. You can only use options of the weapon in question, suitable traits and the ability itself.
7. Count all remaining dice that meet or exceed the enemy's Defense.
8. Deal 1 damage for each success.
9. Resolve any additional effects.

Damage stays on enemies between rounds.

When an enemy has damage equal to or greater than its Health, remove that enemy model.

If that was the last model, discard the enemy reference card, AI cards and trait card.

Spellcasting

A spell begins with Spellcasting X.

X is the number of successes required to cast it. By default, roll **4d6** with difficulty **4+**.

If successes equal or exceed the Spellcasting value, the spell succeeds.

If the spell fails:

- The spell has no effect unless the card says otherwise.
- The cost is still paid.
- The card remains in the hero's hand.
- The hero cannot attempt that same ability again this round.

Some spells have dice options. Dice spent on spell options do not count as casting successes.

Ongoing Effects

Some abilities create effects that stay in play instead of resolving once and ending immediately.

Ongoing effects may include:

- Tokens placed on the board
- Summoned minions
- Persistent bonuses
- Placed magical effects
- Other effects that remain active until something ends them

After resolving an ability with an ongoing effect, discard the ability card as normal unless the card says otherwise.

The ongoing effect remains active even while the ability card is in the discard pile.

If the hero later returns that card to their hand through Meditate or another effect, the ongoing effect does not end.

An ongoing effect ends when:

- The effect's own rules say it ends.
- The hero plays the same ability card again.
- Another rule, ability, or Questbook instruction removes it.

If a hero plays the same ability card again, the previous ongoing effect from that card immediately ends before the new effect is resolved.

If the previous effect placed tokens, remove those tokens before placing new ones.

> **Ability Tokens Placement**
> Every space can have a maximum of one ability token on it, regardless of type, but models can stand on top of ability tokens.

If the previous effect summoned minions, remove those minions before placing the newly summoned minions.

Unless a rule says otherwise, a hero can only have one active ongoing effect from the same ability card at a time.

Minions

Minions are allied models controlled by the heroes. They may come from abilities, adventure rules, or other effects.

Every minion belongs to one hero. A minion acts during that hero's initiative, either immediately before or immediately after that hero's turn.

On its turn, a minion may:

- Move up to its Speed.
- Make one attack.

Minions do not spend Stamina, make Stamina Checks, or use the hero action list.

Unless a rule says otherwise, minions cannot interact with objectives, open treasure chests, use items, Assist, Block or Dodge.

Minions suffer damage normally. If a minion has damage equal to or greater than its Health, remove it from the board.

Minions do not suffer Injuries.

If an ability summons a minion, place it on an unoccupied space adjacent to the summoning hero. If that is not possible, place it on the nearest legal unoccupied space.

Enemy Turns

Enemies act in groups.

Each enemy group uses one Enemy Reference Card and one AI card.

When an enemy group takes its turn, each model in that group activates once, starting with the model closest to the dungeon entrance.

During activation, an enemy usually:

1. Chooses a target.
2. Moves toward that target.
3. Attacks if able.
4. Resolves active abilities or special rules.

Enemy Targeting

Use the targeting priorities on the AI card.

The first targeting line determines the target.
If there is a tie, use the second line.
If there is still a tie, players choose.

An enemy only considers targets it can legally attack this activation after movement.

If no target can be reached, the enemy moves toward the closest hero or allied minion.

Enemy Movement

Enemies move only as far as needed to attack their target.

Melee enemies move until adjacent.

Ranged enemies move until within range and Line of Sight.

Enemy Attacks

Enemies do not roll attack dice.

Enemy attacks deal fixed damage listed on their reference card.

The attacked hero may then defend - see next chapter.

Group Attack Limit

An enemy group's Attacks value (shown in the top right corner of their card) is the total number of attacks that group can make during its turn.

Example: If a group has Attacks 2, only 2 models in that group can attack, even if more models are in range.

When a Hero is Attacked

Resolve incoming damage in this order:

1. Determine enemy damage.
2. The hero may Block or Dodge.
3. Resolve other damage reduction.
4. Make a Toughness Check.
5. Apply remaining damage to Health.
6. If Health reaches 0, the hero dies.

A hero may Block or Dodge against a single attack, not both.

Block

Cost: 1 Stamina
Roll **4d6 against 4+**.

Each success reduces incoming damage by 1.

A hero may Block no more than twice per round.

Dodge

Cost: 1 Fatigue
Roll **4d6 against 4+**.

Each success reduces incoming damage by 1.

After the roll, the hero must move 1 space to a legal unoccupied space.

If the hero cannot move, they cannot Dodge.

Toughness Check

After Block, Dodge, and other reductions, roll 1d6 for each remaining damage.

The difficulty depends on the hero's armor.

If the hero has no armor, the difficulty is 6+.

Each success prevents 1 damage.

If the Toughness Check includes at least one natural 1, the hero draws 1 random Injury card.

After the Toughness Check, any remaining damage is applied to Health.

End Of Round

At the end of a game round, resolve all "end of round" effects from abilities, adventure related special mechanics and so on.

Also discard the AI card of every enemy group.

Death And Resurrection

A hero dies if:

- Their Health reaches 0.
- A rule says they die.
- They must Banish an ability but have no ability cards left.

When a hero dies, remove their standee and place a Fallen Hero token on that space.

Dead heroes do not take turns, make Stamina Checks, or join initiative.

Resurrection Boons

At the beginning of a round, if at least one hero is dead, the party may spend 1 Resurrection Boon to revive one dead hero.
To revive:

1. Remove 1 Resurrection Boon.
2. Remove the Fallen Hero token.
3. Place the hero on that space, or the nearest legal unoccupied space.
4. The hero immediately gains **Heal 6** and **Rest 2**. However they retain status tokens and injures.
5. The hero participates in that round normally.

If all heroes are dead at the same time, the party loses the entire campaign run.

Exploring the Dungeon

Each adventure is divided into rooms.

Rooms are revealed as heroes open doors and explore.

Opening Doors

During a hero's turn, if that hero is adjacent to a door token, they may open it for free, even as part of their movement.

Opening a door:

1. Replaces the door token with an open door token.
2. Reveals the room beyond it.
3. Pauses the current turn.
4. Places all contents shown for that room.
5. Resolves any immediate Questbook instructions.
6. Continues the hero's turn if they still have actions or Stamina.

Only heroes can open doors unless a rule says otherwise.

Revealing Rooms

When a room is revealed, place the full room layout shown in the Questbook.

This may include:

- Enemies
- Props
- Doors
- Objective tokens
- Treasure chests
- Special markers

If enemies are revealed, give each newly revealed enemy group an AI card as normal.

Should their just assigned initiative step have already occured during that round, they act last instead - they will not skip their turn.

Treasure Chests

To open a treasure chest, a hero must be adjacent to it, have Line of Sight, and spend 1 Stamina.

Resolve the chest entry in the Questbook immediately.

A chest can only be opened once.

Items and Equipment

Each hero has:

- 2 hand slots
- 1 armor slot
- 1 accessory slot
- A backpack with no item limit

A hero may equip either:

- Two one-handed items, or
- One two-handed item

A hero may also equip one armor and one accessory.

New items go to the hero's backpack unless a rule says otherwise.

During a Move action, a hero may spend a movement point to re-equip or trade an item with an adjacent hero.

It costs 1 movement point to change hand items, 1 MP to change armor or accessory, and also 1 MP for each item exchanged with an adjacent hero.

Consumables stay in the backpack and do not use equipment slots.

Ending the Adventure

The adventure ends when:

- The objective is completed.
- The objective is failed.

- All heroes are dead.

When the adventure ends, read the matching outro text and rewards in the Questbook.

For your first game, you can stop here.

If you wish to continue, read the full Rule Book to understand the Town Phase, XP spending, difficulty levels, learning abilities and Legacy rules, as well as miscellaneous edge cases that were not covered in this book.

Good luck, adventurer!

Keywords

The game utilizes a plethora of recurring keywords on abilities, items and other game cards.

Use the last section of the full Rule Book to reference them.